colony. Territorial integrity and economic autarky, championing of anti-colonialism, aversion to military alliances and seeking a South Asia free from foreign influence are deemed critical to India. These, above everything else, are the defining elements of India's national interest.

The pursuit of an independent path has always been tied to moral certitude that India ought to be a beacon not only for Asia but also for the entire world. India's policies have generally been framed to build a world based on ideals of peace and international friendship. To create this idealized world, India championed non-alignment; encouraged multilateral cooperation through the United Nations and regional organizations; and supported decolonization and disarmament, including nuclear disarmament.

The importance that India attaches to its place in the world is an essential theme of the annual addresses delivered by the president of India to the joint session of India's parliament at the start of the budget session. The presidential address, modelled on the queen's address to parliament in Britain, gains greater relevance when it is the first speech soon after elections as it lays out the policies of the incoming administration

In his first address as president of the Constituent Assembly, Prasad had voiced hope that the world needed India and would welcome it, unless the world was 'prepared to reel back into barbarism from which it boasts to have emerged'. He assured all countries of the world on behalf of India that 'we propose to stick to our historic tradition to be on terms of friendship and amity with all, that we have no designs against anyone and hope that none will have any against us. We have only one ambition and desire, that is, to make our contribution to the building up of freedom for all and peace among mankind.'[2] To modern India's founding generation, these were not mere platitudes but a description of substantive policy ideas.

Following Prasad's precedent, every presidential address to the joint session of parliament reaffirms the aims of India's foreign policy as being 'peace and friendship in the world, non-alignment and the building of a just